Silver mining
The conical mountain of Cerro Potosí became the chief source of the Spanish Empire's dazzling wealth after the discovery of silver there in 1545. The huge outcrop of silver ore was soon honeycombed with mine workings, as shown in this engraving from the 18th century.

slaves increased—imported for the mining industry, and to work as servants. Many native Americans were used as forced labor, but others were paid as skilled craftsmen to produce fabulous silverwork.

The first transatlantic convoys

From 1503 to 1660 some 16,000 tons of silver were shipped to Seville (compared with 185 tons of gold), tripling the existing silver resources of Europe. Seville was the "mistress" port, enjoying a monopoly on all these precious cargoes until 1680. Each *flota* (a convoy escorted by armed galleons) sailed from Vera Cruz, Cartagena, and Nombre de Díos to Seville over two months. The system worked—there were only two occasions when whole convoys were intercepted and defeated (once in 1628 by Dutchman Piet Heyn and once by the English Admiral Robert Blake in 1657). Individual galleons, so large and laden with bullion and guns, were often wrecked by poor navigation, preyed on by privateers, or swept under in storms, but the impact on the Spanish Crown was relatively light and the *flota* continued to ensure the regular supply of silver and the royal share, the *quinto real* (the royal fifth). From the 1580s Philip II could expect two to three million ducats a year from the treasure fleets, and this flow of coins gave him the freedom to make his audacious attacks on other European powers (see pp.272–73).

The accountants take over

It was not just the sailors who ensured the silver took a secure route, but also the civil servants. They ran an extensive and accountable system of bureaucratic government that was set up to replace the violent, quarrelsome, and independent-minded Conquistadors. The Council of the Indies, established in Spain from 1522, was charged with the business of the new Imperial territories, presenting reports and policy documents to the King, and acting as the link between Spain and the administrators in the Americas. In order to maintain crown control of the new colonies, all the major posts in the colonial administration, from the Viceroys of New Spain (Mexico) and Peru, from judges to senior churchmen, were either fixed-term appointments or always chosen from the Spanish elites—never from those already in the New World. For the next 200 years, government relied on continuous contact between Madrid (which became Spain's permanent capital in 1561) and the great centers of the Atlantic Empire. It could be slow and cumbersome, and the imposition of a Spanish-born ruling class was deeply resented by the "Creole" population of Spaniards born and bred in the New World. But it achieved the aims of the Spanish Crown, preventing the colonies from slipping toward independence, and maintaining a high level of control over the resources of the New World, including, of course, silver production.

Bullion and coins passed from silver merchants on the Seville waterfront to European royal mints, bankers such as the Fuggers and the Genoese, and the newly created bourses in Antwerp and Bruges (see pp.276–77). In exchange came weapons, powder, and troops. Even Elizabeth I (see pp.260–61) and the merchants of England sought to ensure their share of the treasure through loans. The silver trail stretched east via Italy to the Eastern Mediterranean, and across Persia and India into East Asia, where it was the one commodity in steady and undiminishing demand from Europe in exchange for spices, silks, and Chinese porcelain. Silver, in effect, became the foundation of a global economy.

Censer
An elaborate silver church censer from about 1630, suspended by chains and used for burning incense in Catholic ceremonies, shows the direct link between the prosperity of Spanish–American society and silver production.

> "The last load of silver… arrived **just in time** to pay the German infantry and cavalry we are recruiting."
>
> LETTER FROM FRANCISCO DE ERASO, FINANCIAL ADVISOR OF EMPEROR CHARLES V, 1558

The mistress port
Seville was already a thriving trading port when, in 1503, it was given a monopoly on silver brought back by the fleets from Mexico and Peru. Between 1516 and 1525, 499 ships left Seville port for the Indies.

Philip II
Spain's King Philip II was a bureaucratic ruler, issuing decrees, laws, and rules from his fortress-monastery El Escorial. He relied greatly on advisers and officials to run both his government and his armies.

AFTER

The influx of Europeans had a lasting effect on the American continents. It was over 300 years before the emigrants shook off their colonial shackles.

REVOLUTIONARY TIMES
Spanish and Portuguese rule in South America began to crumble during the Napoleonic Wars of the early 1800s **306–07 ››**. Napoleon's invasion of the Iberian peninsula **304–05 ››** undermined Spain's power and inspired independence movements and revolutionaries. This led to the Spanish–American Wars of Independence **318–19 ››** and the Mexican Revolution.

HYBRID CULTURE
Modern festivals such as the *Día de los Muertos* or "Day of the Dead" are a living reminder of how Spanish Catholicism was bolted onto earlier native traditions to create a vibrant and unique celebration.

DAY OF THE DEAD ARTWORK